THE PRACTICAL STEWARD · FREE STARTER KIT

Data Stewardship Starter Kit



Find out who touches your data, name an owner, and start governing on Monday. No new tools, no budget, no council required.

WHAT'S INSIDE

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Who-touches-what map

Map one set of data in an afternoon: where it comes from, where it goes, and who touches it on the way.

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Role cards

Owner, steward, custodian, producer and user. Who decides, who checks, who keeps it safe, in plain English.

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Monday checklist

Five small moves you can make this week, plus an ownership list to write it all down in black and white.

PAGE 4

YOUR AFTERNOON, ABOUT TWO HOURS

15 min
Pick one set of data that people complain about.

60 min
Talk to the people who touch it. Fill in the map.

30 min
Use the role cards to name one owner and the stewards.

15 min
Write it on the ownership list. Share it.

You can't govern data if you don't know who touches it.

Kelvin Tsang · 20+ years in enterprise data across investment management, entertainment and transportation · inoutflows.com

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1 Who-touches-what map

One set of data, one afternoon. Do it by hand: this page, a whiteboard or a spreadsheet is fine. Automated lineage can come later.

DATA SET _____

WHY PEOPLE COMPLAIN ABOUT IT _____

DATE _____

A. WHERE DOES IT COME FROM, AND WHERE DOES IT GO?

Source
Where it's first created or entered

→

Stored or changed
Systems, files, hand-offs

→

Lands in
Reports, dashboards, other systems

→

Decisions it feeds
What breaks if it's wrong?

B. WHO TOUCHES IT?

PERSON OR TEAM	CREATES	UPDATES	USES	DECIDES	USES IT FOR / EXPECTS
	☐	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	☐	

ASK EACH PERSON

1. Do you use this, and for what?
2. What do you expect from it?
3. Do you send updates, or make them?
4. Who do you go to when it's wrong?

Question 4 is the trail to your owner. Keep following it until you reach someone who can decide.

C. WHAT THE MAP TELLS YOU

LIKELY OWNER (THE NAME PEOPLE KEEP POINTING TO) _____

SOURCE OF TRUTH _____

STEWARDS (THE PEOPLE WHO LIVE WITH IT DAILY) _____

RISKS OR SURPRISES YOU FOUND _____

☐ **Nobody owns it, creates it or keeps it up to date?** Ask the hard question: do we need this data at all?

2 Role cards

Stewardship isn't a job title. If you have a relationship with the data, you already have a role. These cards make it official. (The idea that everyone who defines, produces or uses data is already a steward comes from Robert S. Seiner.)

Owner — Decides

One person, not a team. Decides what goes into the data and what stays out, who can use it, and what happens when there's a dispute. Accountable for its value.

Ask: "Who gets to decide when a new record is created, or two are merged?"

Pitch the decision rights, not the extra work. Leaders like having a say.

Steward — Keeps it accurate

Lives with the data every day. Checks it against the rules the owner set: is every value valid, complete and real? Raises problems so they get fixed at the source.

Ask: "When you're not sure what this data means, who do you ask?"

Quiet fixes in private spreadsheets create two versions of the truth.

Custodian — Keeps it safe

Usually IT. Runs the systems and keeps the data secure, available and backed up. Important work, but the custodian doesn't decide what the data means.

Ask: "Who approves changes to this data, other than you?"

"It's in IT's system, so IT owns it." IT builds the kitchen. It doesn't own the food.

Producer — Creates it

Enters or generates the data: a front-line team, a vendor feed, an upstream system. Their habits set the quality before anyone downstream sees it.

Ask: "Do you send updates, or make them? What happens when you get it wrong?"

Fix problems where the data is created, not in every report downstream.

User — Relies on it

Uses the data in reports, decisions and daily work. Usually the first to notice when it's wrong, and the first to stop trusting it.

Ask: "What do you expect from it? What do you do when it's wrong?"

When users stop trusting data, they quietly build their own copy.

Tricky cases — From the field

Shared data. If several teams depend on it equally (exchange rates, say), give it to a central shared data team to own. Common for data you buy from a vendor.

Nobody wants it. Offer the decision rights. If still nobody wants it, ask whether the data is valuable at all.

Everyone says "I own it". Write it down anyway. People forget.

3 Monday checklist

Five small moves. One a week is plenty. Each one comes from an episode of The Practical Steward.

- [ ] **Find your first governance gap** — EPISODE 1
  Pick the report your executives argue about most. Write down who decides what its numbers mean, where that decision is written, and where problems go. Any "nobody", "nowhere" or "my inbox" is a gap.

- [ ] **Follow the trail to the owner** — EPISODE 2
  Ask the people who use the data daily: "When you're not sure what this means, who do you ask?" Follow it to someone who can decide. Write their name next to the data set.

- [ ] **Find your people before you form a council** — EPISODE 3
  List the stewards, data product owners and decision makers who already get why this matters. Govern one data product properly, show the value, then form the council around real decisions.

- [ ] **Ask the board question** — EPISODE 4
  In your next 15 minutes with an executive: "How does the board know the data it uses is correct?" You can have low-quality data. You can't have no measure of it.

- [ ] **Map who touches it** — EPISODE 5
  Use page 2 on the data people complain about most. Then put ownership in writing, below.

OWNERSHIP LIST

DATA SET	OWNER (1 PERSON)	STEWARD(S)	CUSTODIAN	SOURCE	CONFIRMED

Don't assume people know they own the data. Make it black and white, share the list, and check it again every quarter. Ownership is the cornerstone of data governance.

Watch the series
Short, practical episodes on data governance and stewardship. youtube.com/@thepracticalsteward

Learn the full picture
My Udemy course covers data management with DMBOK 2 as the framework. A good base for the CDMP. Take the course on Udemy

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